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Primary Research: Interviews & Surveys

RESOURCES EXIST. ROADBLOCKS DON'T HAVE TO



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INTRODUCTION

Date of Report: October 5, 2025

Date of Interview(s): September 27, 2025; September 28, 2025; September 30, 2025; October 3, 2025.

Our initial project goal was to design a networking app for tradespeople, aiming to connect workers, apprentices, and employers through community engagement and mentorship. However, after conducting surveys and interviews with four trades professionals aged 22–41, we discovered that participants were not as interested in a networking-focused app. Instead, they emphasized difficulties accessing information about available grants, bursaries, and training resources.

Many participants expressed that they had either never heard of financial support programs or found the application process confusing, overly time-consuming, and filled with unclear eligibility criteria. While some respondents used general platforms like Indeed or LinkedIn for job searches, none reported a reliable source for funding information.

These findings revealed a stronger need for financial accessibility and guidance rather than networking features. Combined with the secondary research from Skilled Trades BC and federal apprenticeship reports, the evidence showed that awareness of grants is low and participation rates in funding programs are declining—partly due to the complexity of applications and the end of certain federal support.

Because of this, our project pivoted from a networking app to a grant-focused app, aiming to simplify access to financial resources and improve awareness among tradespeople in British Columbia.

WHO WE INTERVIEWED / SURVEYED

Responses	Age	Gender	Occupation	Experience
User 1	31	man	Plumber	High-term apprentice(Years 2-4)
User 2	24	man	AST	Trades Pre-Employment program
User 3	22	Woman	Landscaper	Low-term apprentice (Years 1-2)
User 4	49	Woman	Gardener	High-term apprentice(Years 2-4)

Findings

Building networks and community within the trades is a worthwhile cause. However, Creating an truly impactful solution differentiated from existing platforms would require features beyond the scope of the project timeline or a work culture shift.

While trade grants are vital for financial support, their effectiveness is limited by two main barriers: low awareness among tradespeople and the complexity of the application process. These non-financial hurdles ,such as confusing steps, strict deadlines, and a lack of clear information, often discourage apprentices from applying.

At the heart of the Scaffold team; is a desire to provide a measurable difference in the lives of the tradespeople it engages. A grant application assistance app can address these gaps directly by raising early awareness, simplifying the application workflow, and connecting users to both financial and non-financial support. Ultimately, this approach would not only increase grant uptake but also help more apprentices successfully complete their training, making it a valid and impactful solution.

02

Secondary Research: Skilled Trades Bc Annual Service Plan

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SKILLED TRADES BC ANNUAL SERVICE PLAN REPORT

The Annual Service Plans in 2023/2024 and 2024/2025 Summarize Skill Trades BC's progress towards their financial and organizational objectives. They were selected as secondary because they numerically represent participation in programs established to advance tradespeople in British Columbia over a three year period.

Program/ Initiative + aim	2023/2024 Participants	2024/2025 participants	% Change	Notes
Work BC Canada-British Columbia Workforce Development Agreement	Baseline established December 2023 (No Stated Metrics)	1,100 Indigenous people, women and those in equity-deserving groups across the province.	N/A	NA
BWITTT partnership: New women apprenticeship registrations in underrepresented trades	1,341	979	-36.98%	Downward trend
Funding to increase the proportionality of women in under-represented trades	6.7%	6.6%	+0.1%	Downward trend
BCWITT: Women in under-represented trades training environments are free of racism, sexism and discrimination Technical Training	88%	92%	+4%	Upward Trend
BCWITT: Women in under-represented trades training environments are free of racism, sexism and discrimination On-the-Job-Training	76%	75%	-1%	Downward trend

FINDINGS

BCWITT: Women in under-represented trades training environments are free of racism, sexism and discrimination technical training showcased 4% participation growth over the three year period that was analyzed. The remaining initiatives all showed a decrease in participation (the Work BC Canada-British Columbia Workforce Development Agreement was excluded from this statement due to the lack of data). Upon further research the cause of the decline was attributed “ in part, to the ending of the federally distributed Canadian Apprenticeship Service grant incentivizing employers to hire first-year apprentices from equity deserving groups, including women (available from 2022/23 to 2023/24).” The reduction in the number of resources has a direct negative impact on recruitment and retention of tradespeople. Scaffold’s aim is to increase recruitment and retention within the skilled trades by streamlining access and application to grants and resources as well as increasing awareness of their availability. In so doing, scaffold endeavors to contribute to increasing the figures in the 2025/2026 year despite the reduction in resources.

03

Secondary Research: Trades Grant Awareness & Application resources

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TRADES GRANTS AWARENESS & APPLICATION BARRIERS

Purpose

To understand how easy or hard it is to apply for trades grants in Canada and how aware tradespeople are of these opportunities.

1. Canadian Federal Apprenticeship Grants. (Apprenticeship Incentive Grant (AIG), Apprenticeship Completion Grant (ACG), and Women in Trades Grant (AIG-W))

- The program allowed eligible apprentices to receive up to CA\$4,000 lifetime across the various grant components. The report discusses take-up rates, barriers to applying, and awareness issues.
- One constraint: applications and supporting documents for many grants must be submitted by certain deadlines; for example, applications for the Apprenticeship Incentive Grant must be submitted by March 31, 2025 (for some progressions).¹
- There is recognition that many apprentices only became aware of the grants after they entered apprenticeship programs, rather than before (so the grant didn't influence the decision to enroll). The evaluation also notes that some of the supporting-document submission is burdensome and delays can occur.

TRADES GRANTS AWARENESS & APPLICATION BARRIERS

Canadian Federal Apprenticeship Grants: Evaluation & Constraints

2. BC-specific Grants:

- BC has several employer-based tax credits and grants for apprentices (e.g. BC Apprentice Employer Tax Credit, Employer Training Grant) as part of its strategies. These are often more on the employer side rather than the apprentice side.
- BC also offers a BC Access Grant for low- and middle-income students in pre-apprenticeship/foundation programs (up to CA\$4,000).
- B.C. Training Tax Credit (TTC) is a refundable tax credit available to both apprentices and employers, that provide apprentices to claim up to \$2,000 for progression/completion. It supports retention by rewarding completion milestones but some apprentices find it complex in tax filing what discourages them from claiming.'
- WorkBC Apprentice Services reduces non-tuition barriers by providing support during technical training: living costs, travel, childcare, and disability-related costs. Application complexity and documentation requirements can still discourage uptake.
- The "Barriers to employment and training for equity-seeking groups" (University of Ottawa / SRDC) report synthesizes research on systemic barriers faced by underrepresented groups in accessing training and employment supports. Groups with intersecting disadvantages (Indigenous, visible minorities, people with disabilities) often face information barriers, access gaps, transportation or childcare burden, stigma, and bureaucratic barriers in applying for training support. The report emphasizes that simply offering a grant is insufficient; people face non-financial barriers (logistics, support, etc.) that reduce uptake.

KEY FINDINGS

1. Awareness of Grants

- Many apprentices only learn about federal grants after starting their training.
- Awareness varies by trade, gender, and region. Word of mouth and employers are the main sources of information.

2. Application Experience

- Application processes are seen as bureaucratic, with confusing steps and documentation.
- Some still find applying manageable once they know about the grant, but others report difficulty navigating online systems.

3. Barriers Beyond Funding

- Financial help matters, but non-financial barriers are bigger: lack of information, employer hesitancy, and difficulty balancing work/training.
- Many apprentices drop out before completion due to inconsistent hours, limited guidance, or lack of awareness of available support.

4. Recent Trends

- Industry groups (e.g., PCA, REMI Network) warn that reduced or cancelled grants could further discourage apprenticeships.
- Online forums (Reddit, trades communities) show frustration about late awareness and uncertainty around funding changes.

Implications for Resource Application Assistance App

- **Simplification Needed:** Apprentices find grant applications confusing and inconsistent.
- **Awareness Gap:** A centralized, user-friendly way to discover grants early could make a big difference.
- **Beyond Money:** App should also point users toward mentorship, employer info, and completion support.

04

Recommendations & Conclusion

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RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Onboarding / “pre-entry” awareness

- A “What supports are available to me” quiz / preview tool that surfaces grants before people commit.
- Use push / email / marketing to likely audiences (high school students, career-change folks) because many only discover grants inside the system.

2. Eligibility checker

- Eligibility checks upon initial application viewing with yes/no logic. (ex: “you’re eligible”)
- Progressive disclosure of

3. Document preparation & smart reminders

- Help users gather supporting docs ahead of deadlines (e.g. transcripts, registration proof).
- Reminder nudges for approaching deadlines or missing materials.

4. Simplified, guided multi-step flows

- Break applications into bite-sized sub-steps (eligibility → forms → upload → verification).
- Use progressive disclosure (only show what’s needed next).
- Tooltips or inline help for clarifying terms/requirements.

5. Transparency & trust signals

- Show grant source (government agency name, link).
- Show historical data (e.g. how many people in your trade have succeeded in applying).
- User testimonials / success stories (if permitted) to build credibility.

6. Alternate funding pathways

- Because federal grants are winding down, include alternate programs (provincial grants, bursaries, tax credits, loans).
- For users who fail grant approval, show fallback options (loan, scholarship, employer-based support).

CONCLUSION

The research confirms that while trades grants provide important financial support, many apprentices either remain unaware of them or face challenges when applying. Low awareness, confusing application steps, and strict deadlines limit the effectiveness of existing programs. These barriers suggest that financial aid alone is not enough. Clearer guidance and accessible tools are essential.

By addressing these gaps, a grant application advisor app has strong potential to make a meaningful impact. It could raise awareness early, simplify application processes, and connect tradespeople to both financial and non-financial support. Ultimately, this approach would not only improve grant uptake but also help more apprentices successfully complete their training.

Resources

1. SkilledTradesBC 2023/24 Annual Service Plan Report.2024.(p.12-19)
2. SkilledTradesBC 2024/25 Annual Service Plan Report. 2025.(p.11-18)
3. ESDC – Apprenticeship Grants Evaluation Report (2025 & 2019) – shows barriers, awareness gaps, and uptake rates.
4. Canadian Apprenticeship Forum – Barriers to Attracting Apprentices – highlights costs, lack of information, and employer hesitancy.
5. Statistics Canada – Factors Associated with Completion of Apprenticeship (2020) – data on dropouts and challenges.
6. HEQCO – Apprenticeship Training Literature Review – reviews awareness issues and information barriers.
7. Pre-Apprenticeship Consultation Report (2021) – focuses on how awareness and supports influence entry.
8. RBC Thought Leadership – Skilled Trades Report – industry outlook, mentions training and funding barriers.
9. Reddit & News (REMI Network, PCA) – anecdotal evidence on difficulty applying and awareness of grants.